

Thesis Notes

Nathaniel Kenschaft

May 27, 2026

Contents

0.1	TODO	2
0.2	Notation	3
1	Background	4
1.1	Background from [Far06]	5
1.2	Background from [CG13]	11
1.3	Background from [DLS24]	16
2	New Work	17
2.1	Sectional Category and Canonicalization	18
2.2	Bounds for Strong and Weak Sectional Category	20
2.3	Canonicalizing $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$	22

0.1 TODO

1. Read ~~[Far06]~~
2. Read ~~[CG13]~~
3. Read [DLS24]
4. Ok so there's no continuous section in [DLS24], but what is the Schwarz genus? I.e. how many cases are there?
5. Is it a good idea to just canonicalize via $\mathbb{S}_d^n$? Why or why not?
6. What can we learn about $X = \{A \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times n} : \text{rank}(A) = d\}$ and $X/O(d)$ or $X/SO(d)$?
7. Is a canonicalization up to homotopy sufficient?
8. Use restrictions to bound sectional category on original space
9. Consider $SO(d)$ acting on $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$
10. Understand proof that there is no canonicalization of $(\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}, O(d))$ and $(\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}, SO(d))$.
11. Consider what group acts on vectorized images and consider Schwarz genus
12. What if we want a *differentiable* section?

0.2 Notation

- I use $A \cong B$ to denote that there exists an isomorphism between A and B in whatever the appropriate category is. For instance if X and Y are topological spaces then $X \cong Y$ means X and Y are homeomorphic, or if G and H are groups then $G \cong H$ means G and H are isomorphic as groups.
- For a homotopy $h : X \times [0, 1] \rightarrow Y$, I may also write $h_t : X \rightarrow Y$ with $h_t(x) := h(x, t)$.
- For any set X , I write c_x to mean the constant function at $x \in X$.
- Given a path $\gamma : [0, 1] \rightarrow X$, I write $\bar{\gamma}$ to mean the reversed path $\bar{\gamma}(t) := \gamma(1 - t)$.
- For any two paths $\alpha, \beta : [0, 1] \rightarrow X$ with $\alpha(1) = \beta(0)$, I write $\beta * \alpha$ to indicate their concatenation:

$$(\beta * \alpha)(t) = \begin{cases} \alpha(2t) & \text{if } 0 \leq t \leq \frac{1}{2} \\ \beta(2t - 1) & \text{if } \frac{1}{2} \leq t \leq 1 \end{cases}.$$

The exact parameterization is unimportant, but if it ever matters this is what I mean.

- Unless specified otherwise, for any group G I will write $e \in G$ to be the identity in G . If there is the potential for confusion between different groups, I will use subscripts to differentiate (e.g. e_G is the identity in G , e_H is the identity in H).
- I write $\mathbb{R}_{\text{rank } k}^{d \times n}$ to mean the set $\{A \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times n} : \text{rank}(A) = k\}$ and set $\mathbb{R}_*^{d \times n} = \mathbb{R}_{\text{rank } d}^{d \times n}$.

Chapter 1

Background

1.1 Background from [Far06]

Definition 1.1. For a topological space X and positive integer n ,

$$F(X, n) = \{(x_1, \dots, x_n) \in X^n : x_i \neq x_j \text{ for } i \neq j\}.$$

Intuitively, this gives the configuration space of n particles moving through X with no collisions.

Definition 1.2. For fixed $a = (a_1, \dots, a_m) \in \mathbb{R}_+^m$, we define the variety

$$M(a) = \left\{ (z_1, \dots, z_m) \in (S^2)^m : \sum_{i=1}^m a_i z_i = 0 \right\} / SO(3)$$

where $SO(3)$ acts coordinate-wise on $(S^2)^m$. This variety describes all polygons in $\mathbb{R}^3$ with sidelengths $a_1, \dots, a_m$.

Definition 1.3. Let X be a path-connected topological space. Then $PX = C([0, 1]; X)$ is the space of all paths $\gamma : [0, 1] \rightarrow X$ equipped with the compact-open topology.

Recall that the compact-open topology has a subbase given by sets of the form

$$V(K, U) := \{f \in C(X, Y) : f[K] \subseteq U\}$$

for $K \subseteq [0, 1]$ compact and $U \subseteq X$ open [wikipedia:compact-open].

Definition 1.4. For spaces E and B , a map $p : E \rightarrow B$ has the homotopy lifting property (HLP) for a space X if for every homotopy $h_t : X \rightarrow B$ and every lift $\tilde{h}_0 : X \rightarrow E$ of h_0 ($h_0 = p \circ \tilde{h}_0$), there exists a homotopy $\tilde{h}_t : X \rightarrow E$ that lifts h_t ($h_t = p \circ \tilde{h}_t$).

Definition 1.5. For spaces E and B , a map $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a (Hurewicz) fibration if p satisfies the homotopy lifting property for all topological spaces [Wik26b].

Remark 1.1. The map $\pi : PX \rightarrow X \times X$ given by $\pi(\gamma) = (\gamma(0), \gamma(1))$ is a fibration.

Proof. Let Y be any topological space and let $h_t : Y \rightarrow X \times X$ be a homotopy with some $\tilde{h}_0 : Y \rightarrow PX$ such that $h_0 = \pi \circ \tilde{h}_0$. Then we simply define

$$\tilde{h}_t(y)(s) = \begin{cases} (h_{t(1-3s)}(y))_1 & \text{if } 0 \leq s \leq \frac{1}{3} \\ \tilde{h}_0(y)(3(s - \frac{1}{3})) & \text{if } \frac{1}{3} \leq s \leq \frac{2}{3} \\ (h_{t(3s-2)}(y))_2 & \text{if } \frac{2}{3} \leq s \leq 1 \end{cases}.$$

Intuitively, this simply defines a path from $(h_t(y))_1$ to $(h_t(y))_2$ by following:

1. $(h_\bullet(y))_1$ from $(h_t(y))_1$ to $(h_0(y))_1$,
2. $\tilde{h}_0$ from $(h_0(y))_1 = \tilde{h}_0(y)(0)$ ($h_0 = \pi \circ \tilde{h}_0$) to $\tilde{h}_0(y)(1)$,
3. and $(h_\bullet(y))_2$ from $\tilde{h}_0(y)(1) = (h_0(y))_2$ ($\pi \circ \tilde{h}_0 = h_0$) to $(h_t(y))_2$.

By construction $\tilde{h}_t$ is continuous, so we conclude that π is a fibration. $\square$

Definition 1.6. A motion planning algorithm is a section $s : X \times X \rightarrow PX$ of π , i.e. $\pi \circ s = \text{id}_{X \times X}$.

Lemma 1.1. A continuous motion planning algorithm in X exists if and only if X is contractible.

Proof. First assume that there exists a continuous motion planning algorithm, i.e. a continuous section $s : X \times X \rightarrow PX$ of π , and fix some $x_0 \in X$. Then for every $x \in X$, define $\gamma_x = s(x_0, x) \in PX$. Now define a homotopy $h_t : X \rightarrow X$ via $h_t(x) = \gamma_x(t)$. Observe that $h_0(x) = \gamma_x(0) = x_0$ and $h_1(x) = \gamma_x(1) = x$ so $h_0 = c_{x_0}$ and $h_1 = \text{id}_X$. Since s is continuous, this means that h is a homotopy from c_{x_0} to id_X and therefore X is contractible.

Now instead assume that X is contractible and let $h_t : X \rightarrow X$ be a homotopy exhibiting this ($h_0 = c_{x_0}$ for some $x_0 \in X$ and $h_1 = \text{id}_X$). Then for each $x \in X$, define $\gamma_x \in PX$ via $\gamma_x(t) = h_t(x)$ and define $s : X \times X \rightarrow PX$ by $s(x, y) = \gamma_y * \overline{\gamma_x}$. Then s is a section since $\pi(s(x, y)) = ((\gamma_y * \overline{\gamma_x})(0), (\gamma_y * \overline{\gamma_x})(1)) = (x, y)$, and s is continuous by construction. $\square$

Definition 1.7. A topological space X is a Euclidean Neighborhood Retract (ENR) if there exists an embedding $i : X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ for some n with an open neighborhood U of $i[X]$ such that U retracts onto $i[X]$.

Definition 1.8. A motion planning algorithm $s : X \times X \rightarrow PX$ is tame if there are finitely many disjoint sets $F_i \subseteq X \times X$ such that $X \times X = \cup_i F_i$, $s|_{F_i}$ is continuous, and F_i is an ENR.

Definition 1.9. The topological complexity of a tame motion planning algorithm is the minimum number of sets F_i one can take in definition 1.8.

Definition 1.10. For a path-connected space X , the topological complexity $\text{TC}_1(X)$ is the minimum topological complexity of tame motion planning algorithms in X . We set $\text{TC}_1(X) = \infty$ if X admits no tame motion planning algorithms.

Remark 1.2. $\text{TC}_1(X) = 1$ if and only if X is a contractible ENR.

Proof. This trivially follows from lemma 1.1 and definitions 1.7 and 1.8. $\square$

Definition 1.11. The Schwarz genus or sectional category of a fibration $p : E \rightarrow B$, denoted $\text{secat}(p)$ is the minimum number k of open sets $U_1, \dots, U_k$ covering B such that each U_j admits a continuous section $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ of p .

Remark 1.3. The Schwarz genus of a fibration $p : E \rightarrow B$ is 1 if and only if p admits a continuous section $s : B \rightarrow E$.

Definition 1.12. For a path-connected pointed space (X, x_0) , we define

$$P_0X := \{\gamma \in C([0, 1]; X) : \gamma(0) = x_0\}.$$

Definition 1.13. For a path-connected pointed space (X, x_0) , the Lusternik-Schnirelmann category of X , denoted $\text{cat}(X)$, is the Schwarz genus of the fibration $\pi_0 : P_0X \rightarrow X, \gamma \mapsto \gamma(1)$.

Definition 1.14. For a path-connected space X , the topological complexity $\mathbf{TC}_2(X)$ is the Schwarz genus of the fibration $\pi : PX \rightarrow X \times X$.

Remark 1.4. $\mathbf{TC}_2(X) = 1$ if and only if X is contractible.

Proof. This is a direct corollary of lemma 1.1. $\square$

Lemma 1.2. Let $p : E \rightarrow B$ be a fibration, and let $B' \subseteq B$ with $E' := p^{-1}[B']$ and $p' = p|_{E'} : E' \rightarrow B'$. Then $\text{secat}(p') \leq \text{secat}(p)$.

Proof. Assume the $\text{secat}(p) < \infty$ and consider a corresponding minimal set of U_i 's with local sections $s_i : U_i \rightarrow E$ of p . Observe that $s_i|_{B'} : U_i \cap B' \rightarrow E'$ is then a local section of p' , so $\text{secat}(p') \leq \text{secat}(p)$. If $\text{secat}(p) = \infty$, we trivially conclude $\text{secat}(p') \leq \infty = \text{secat}(p)$, so in either case the Schwarz genus of p' is bounded above by that of p .¹ $\square$

Lemma 1.3. For any fibration $p : E \rightarrow B$, $\text{secat}(p) \leq \text{cat}(B)$.

*Proof.*² Take $\text{cat}(B)$ -many open sets U_i with continuous sections $s_i : U_i \rightarrow P_0B$ of $\pi_0 : P_0B \rightarrow B$. Observe that each s_i induces a homotopy $h_i : U_i \times [0, 1] \rightarrow B$ via $h_i(u, t) := s_i(u)(t)$. Then with the base point $b_0 \in B$, we can fix a corresponding element $e_0 \in p^{-1}[\{b_0\}] \subseteq E$ and define $\tilde{h}_i : U_i \times \{0\} \rightarrow E$ by $\tilde{h}_i(u, 0) = e_0$. This gives us that $p(\tilde{h}_i(u, 0)) = p(e_0) = b_0 = s_i(u)(0) = h_i(u, 0)$, so by the homotopy lifting property of p there exists a homotopy $\tilde{h}_i : U_i \times [0, 1] \rightarrow E$ such that $p \circ \tilde{h}_i = h_i$. Then observe we can define maps $r_i : U_i \rightarrow E$ via $r_i(u) := \tilde{h}_i(u, 1)$, giving us $p(r_i(u)) = p(\tilde{h}_i(u, 1)) = h_i(u, 1) = u$. We therefore conclude that each r_i is a continuous section of p and so $\text{secat}(p) \leq \text{cat}(B)$. $\square$

Proposition 1.1. For a path-connected space X , $\text{cat}(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_2(X) \leq \text{cat}(X \times X)$.

Proof. We have the fibration $\pi : PX \rightarrow X \times X$ from before, as well as $\pi_0 : P_0X \rightarrow X \times X$ given by $\pi_0(\gamma) = (x_0, \gamma(1))$. Observe that $\text{cat}(X)$ is exactly the Schwarz genus of π_0 and $P_0X = \pi^{-1}[\{x_0\} \times X]$, so we immediately know by lemma ?? that $\text{cat}(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_2(X)$. Then by lemma 1.3 we conclude $\mathbf{TC}_2(X) = \text{secat}(\pi : PX \rightarrow X \times X) \leq \text{cat}(X \times X)$. $\square$

Theorem 1.1. $\mathbf{TC}_2$ is a homotopy invariant.

Definition 1.15. The order of instability of the composition in definition 1.8 is the maximum r such that there is some sequence of indices $1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_r \leq k$ where $\overline{F_{i_1}} \cap \dots \cap \overline{F_{i_r}}$ is non-empty. The order of instability of a motion planning algorithm s is then the minimum order of instability of decompositions for s .

Definition 1.16. The topological complexity $\mathbf{TC}_3(X)$ is the minimum order of instability of all tame motion planning algorithms in X .

Remark 1.5. $\mathbf{TC}_3(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_1(X)$.

Proof. This immediately follows from definitions 1.10 and 1.16. $\square$

¹If one wishes to more precisely compare cardinalities, the reasoning in the finite case works.

²Consulted Claude for the basic idea in this proof.

Definition 1.17. A random n -valued path σ in X is a pair of n -tuples $(\gamma_1, \dots, \gamma_n) \in (PX)^n$ and $(p_1, \dots, p_n) \in [0, 1]^n$ such that all the γ_i 's have the same start and end points and $p_1 + \dots + p_n = 1$. We write σ as a formal linear combination $\sigma = p_1\gamma_1 + \dots + p_n\gamma_n$.

We then define P_nX to be the set of all n -valued random paths in X with the subspace topology induced by $\bigoplus_n PX$, and we have the same fibration $\pi : P_nX \rightarrow X \times X$ as before taking n -valued random paths to their end points.

Definition 1.18. An n -valued random motion planning algorithm is a continuous section $s : X \times X \rightarrow P_nX$ of π .

Observe that $s(x, y)$ is simply a probability distribution on n paths from x to y .

Definition 1.19. The topological complexity $\mathbf{TC}_4(X)$ is the minimum integer n such that there is some n -valued random motion planning algorithm $s : X \times X \rightarrow P_nX$.

Theorem 1.2. If X is a simplicial polyhedron, then

$$\mathbf{TC}_1(X) = \mathbf{TC}_2(X) = \mathbf{TC}_3(X) = \mathbf{TC}_4(X).$$

Proof sketch. The proof proceeds in steps:

- Step 1. $\mathbf{TC}_1(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_2(X)$: Expand each F_i to a U_i that deformation retracts back onto it and use the deformation retract to extend $s|_{F_i} : F_i \rightarrow PX$ so $s_i : U_i \rightarrow PX$.
- Step 2. $\mathbf{TC}_2(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_1(X)$: Trim each U_i just enough to get disjoint F_i 's that are ENRs.
- Step 3. $\mathbf{TC}_3(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_2(X)$: Same basic idea as step 1.
- Step 4. $\mathbf{TC}_1(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_3(X)$: Done already in remark 1.5.
- Step 5. $\mathbf{TC}_2(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_4(X)$: Construct open sets $U_j \subseteq X \times X$ from the functions $p_j : X \times X \rightarrow [0, 1]$, and conclude by construction.
- Step 6. $\mathbf{TC}_4(X) \leq \mathbf{TC}_2(X)$: Extend the s_i 's arbitrarily, weight them via a partition of unity, and conclude.

□

Definition 1.20. Moving forward, we define the topological complexity of a space X to be $\mathbf{TC}(X) := \mathbf{TC}_2(X)$.

Definition 1.21. The order of an open cover $\mathcal{U}$ of X is the least integer n such that each point of X belongs to at most n sets of $\mathcal{U}$ (if such an integer exists) [Wik26c].

Definition 1.22. The covering dimension of a space X , denoted $\dim X$, to be the least integer n such that every finite open cover $\mathcal{U}$ of X has a refinement $\mathcal{V}$ of order $n + 1$. If no such n exists, then we set $\dim X = \infty$ [Wik26c].

Lemma 1.4. Let X be a path-connected paracompact locally contractible space. Then

$$\text{cat}(X) \leq \dim(X) + 1.$$

Lemma 1.5. *Let X be a path-connected paracompact locally contractible space. Then*

$$\dim(X \times X) = 2 \dim X.$$

Theorem 1.3. *Let X be a path-connected paracompact locally contractible space. Then*

$$\mathbf{TC}(X) \leq 2 \dim X + 1.$$

Proof. By lemmas 1.3, 1.4, and 1.5 we have

$$\mathbf{TC}(X) \leq \text{cat}(X \times X) \leq \dim(X \times X) + 1 = 2 \dim X + 1.$$

□

Theorem 1.4. *Let X be an r -connected CW-complex. Then*

$$\mathbf{TC}(X) \leq \frac{2 \dim X + 1}{r + 1} + 1.$$

Definition 1.23. *The tensor product $H^\bullet(X) \otimes H^\bullet(X)$ is a graded algebra with multiplication given by*

$$(u_1 \otimes v_1) \cdot (u_2 \otimes v_2) = (-1)^{|v_1||u_2|} (u_1 u_2) \otimes (v_1 v_2)$$

where $|x|$ denotes the degree of the cohomology class of x .

Definition 1.24. *The cup product $\smile: H^k(X) \otimes H^\ell(X) \rightarrow H^{k+\ell}(X)$ is given by*

$$(\alpha \smile \beta)(\sigma) := \alpha(\sigma_{[0, \dots, k]}) \cdot \beta(\sigma_{[k, \dots, k+\ell]}).$$

Note that this means $\smile$ induces a graded algebra $H^\bullet(X)$.

Definition 1.25. *The ideal of the zero-divisors of $H^\bullet(X)$ is the kernel of*

$$\smile: H^\bullet(X) \otimes H^\bullet(X) \rightarrow H^\bullet(X).$$

Definition 1.26. *The zero-divisors-cup-length of $H^\bullet(X)$ is the length of the longest non-trivial product in the ideal of zero-divisors of $H^\bullet(X)$.*

Theorem 1.5. *$\mathbf{TC}(X)$ is greater than the zero-divisors-cup-length of $H^\bullet(X)$.*

Example 1.1. *Consider S^n , letting $u \in H^n(S^n)$ be the fundamental class and $1 \in H^0(S^n)$ be the unit. Recall that $H^k(S^n) = 0$ for $k \neq 0, n$, and note $H^n(S^n) = \langle u \rangle$ and $H^0(S^n) = \langle 1 \rangle$. We then set $a = u \otimes 1 - 1 \otimes u$ and $b = u \otimes u$, and note that, up to coefficients, a and b are the only (potentially) interesting elements of $H^\bullet(S^n) \otimes H^\bullet(S^n)$. Observe that $u^2 \in H^{2n}(S^n) = 0$ so $u^2 = 0$ and we compute*

$$\begin{aligned} a \cdot a &= (u \otimes 1 - 1 \otimes u) \cdot (u \otimes 1 - 1 \otimes u) \\ &= (u \otimes 1) \cdot (u \otimes 1) - (u \otimes 1) \cdot (1 \otimes u) - (1 \otimes u) \cdot (u \otimes 1) + (1 \otimes u) \cdot (1 \otimes u) \\ &= (-1)^{|1||u|} (u^2 \otimes 1^2) - (-1)^{|1||1|} (u \otimes u) - (-1)^{|u||u|} (u \otimes u) + (-1)^{|u||1|} (1^2 \otimes u^2) \\ &= -u \otimes u - (-1)^{n^2} (u \otimes u) \\ &= ((-1)^{n+1} - 1) u \otimes u. \end{aligned}$$

So if n is even then $a^2 = -2b$ and if n is odd $a^2 = 0$, giving us that the zero-divisors-cup-length of $H^\bullet(S^n)$ is 1 for odd n and 2 for even n .

Theorem 1.6. For spaces X and Y ,

$$\mathbf{TC}(X \times Y) \leq \mathbf{TC}(X) + \mathbf{TC}(Y) - 1.$$

Corollary 1.1. For spaces $X_1, \dots, X_n$ with $\mathbf{TC}(X_i) \leq M$ for all $1 \leq i \leq n$,

$$\mathbf{TC}(X_1 \times \dots \times X_n) \leq nM - 1.$$

Theorem 1.7. For n path-connected spaces X_i that are (co)homologically nontrivial,

$$\mathbf{TC}(X_1 \times \dots \times X_n) \geq n + 1.$$

Corollary 1.2. For n path-connected spaces X_i that are (co)homologically nontrivial,

$$\mathbf{TC}(X_1 \times \dots \times X_n)$$

grows linearly with n .

Proof. This follows directly from corollary 1.1 and theorem 1.7. $\square$

Proposition 1.2. For $U \subseteq X \times X$, there exists a section $s : U \rightarrow PX$ of $\pi : PX \rightarrow X \times X$ if and only if the inclusion $i : U \hookrightarrow X \times X$ is homotopic to some diagonal map $f : U \rightarrow X \times X$ (i.e. $f[U]$ is contained in the diagonal of $X \times X$).

Proof. First assume we have a section $s : U \rightarrow PX$ of π and consider the diagonal map $f : U \rightarrow X \times X$ given by $f(x, y) := (y, y)$. Then we can construct a homotopy $h_t : U \rightarrow X \times X$ by $h_t(x, y) := (s(x, y)(t), y)$. Observe that $h_0(x, y) = (x, y) = i(x, y)$ and $h_1(x, y) = (y, y) = f(x, y)$ so we have a homotopy from $i : U \rightarrow X \times X$ to a diagonal map $f : U \rightarrow X \times X$.

Conversely, assume we have a homotopy $h_t : U \rightarrow X \times X$ such that $h_0 = i$ and $h_1 =: f$ is a diagonal map; denote $\hat{f} = f_1 = f_2$. Then for some $(x, y) \in U$, we have two paths, $\gamma_1(t) = (h_t(x, y))_1$ from x to $\hat{f}(x, y)$ and $\gamma_2(t) = (h_t(x, y))_2$ from y to $\hat{f}(x, y)$. Then we can define $s : U \rightarrow PX$ by $s(x, y) = \overline{\gamma_2} * \gamma_1$, and by construction we have $\pi \circ s = \text{id}$ $\square$

Corollary 1.3. The topological complexity $\mathbf{TC}(X) = \mathbf{TC}_2(X)$ is the smallest integer k such that $X \times X$ can be covered by k open sets where each inclusion $U_j \hookrightarrow X \times X$ is homotopic to a diagonal map $f : U \rightarrow X \times X$.

Proof. This follows immediately from definition 1.14 and proposition 1.2. $\square$

Proposition 1.3. If X is an ENR then

$$\mathbf{TC}(X) \geq \text{cat}((X \times X)/\Delta X) - 1$$

where $\Delta X \subseteq X \times X$ is the diagonal.

1.2 Background from [CG13]

Definition 1.27. The sectional category of a map $p : E \rightarrow B$, denoted $\text{secat}(p)$, is the least integer k such that B may be covered by k open sets U_j that each admit a map $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ where $p \circ s_j$ is homotopic to the inclusion $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$.

Remark 1.6. For a fibration $p : E \rightarrow B$, definition 1.27 corresponds to definition 1.11 given in [Far06].

Proof. First, let U_j and $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ be as in definition 1.11, i.e. $p \circ s_j = i_j$. Then trivially $p \circ s_i \simeq i_j$.

Conversely, let U_j and $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ be as in definition 1.27, i.e. $p \circ s_j \simeq i_j$, and fix some $j \leq k$. Let $h_t : U_j \rightarrow B$ be the homotopy witnessing $p \circ s_j \simeq i_j$ with $h_0 = p \circ s_j$ and $h_1 = i_j$. We define the map $\tilde{h}_0 : U_j \rightarrow E$ by $\tilde{h}_0 = s_j$, and observe that by construction $p \circ \tilde{h}_0 = p \circ s_j = h_0$. Then by the homotopy lifting property we have a homotopy $\tilde{h}_t : U_j \rightarrow E$ such that $p \circ \tilde{h}_t = h_t$. In particular, this gives us a map $\hat{s}_j := \tilde{h}_1 U_j \rightarrow E$ such that $p \circ \hat{s}_j = h_1 = i_j$. $\square$

Definition 1.28. The Lusternik-Schnirelmann category of a space X , denoted $\text{cat}(X)$, is the least integer k such that X may be covered by k open sets U_j where each inclusion $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow X$ is null-homotopic.

Remark 1.7. For a path-connected space X , definition 1.28 corresponds to definition 1.13 given in [Far06]. Note that definition 1.13 only makes sense if X is path-connected anyway.

Proof. First, let $U_j \subseteq X$ and $s_j : U_j \rightarrow P_0 X$ be as in definition 1.13, i.e. $\pi_0 \circ s_j = i_j$. We then simply define a homotopy $h_t : U_j \rightarrow X$ via $h_t(x) = s_j(x)(t)$, so $h_0(x) = s_j(x)(0) = x_0$ and $h_1(x) = s_j(x)(1) = x$. Therefore $h_0 = c_{x_0}$ and $h_1 = i_j$, so $c_{x_0} \simeq i_j$.

Conversely, let $U_j \subseteq X$ be as in definition 1.28 with $i_j \simeq c_{x_j}$ for some $x_j \in X$. Since X is path-connected all constant maps are homotopic, so without loss of generality each $x_j = x_0$. Fixing some j , let $h_t : U_j \rightarrow X$ be the homotopy witnessing $i_j \simeq c_{x_0}$ where $h_0 = c_{x_0}$ and $h_1 = i_j$. Then we define $s_j : U_j \rightarrow P_0 X$ by $s_j(x)(t) = h_t(x)$, so

$$\pi_0(s_j(x)) = s_j(x)(1) = h_1(x) = i_j(x) = x.$$

$\square$

Proposition 1.4. For any spaces E and B along with a surjective map $p : E \rightarrow B$, $\text{secat}(p) \leq \text{cat}(B)$.

Proof. Take $\text{cat}(B)$ -many open sets U_j such that $B = \cup_j U_j$ and each inclusion $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$ is homotopic to a constant map $c_j : U_j \rightarrow B$. For each j , fix $e_j \in p^{-1}[c_j[U_j]]$ and define $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ by $s_j = c_{e_j}$. Observe that $p \circ s_j = c_j$ by definition, so $p \circ s_j \simeq i_j$. Therefore $\text{secat}(p) \leq \text{cat}(B)$. $\square$

Proposition 1.5. For a contractible space E and any space B along with a map $p : E \rightarrow B$, $\text{cat}(B) \leq \text{secat}(p)$.

Proof. Take $\text{secat}(p)$ -many open sets U_j with $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ such that $B = \cup_j U_j$ and $p \circ s_j \simeq i_j$. Since E is contractible we have that each map s_j is homotopic to a constant map c_j , and immediately this means that $p \circ s_j$ is homotopic to $p \circ c_j$ which is also constant. Therefore $i_j \simeq p \circ c_j$ and U_j is null-homotopic so $\text{cat}(B) \leq \text{secat}(p)$. $\square$

Corollary 1.4. *If E is a contractible space, B is any space, and $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a surjection, then $\text{secat}(p) = \text{cat}(B)$.*

Proof. This directly follows from propositions 1.4 and 1.5. $\square$

Definition 1.29. *Given a commutative ring R and an ideal $I \subseteq R$, the nilpotency of I , denoted $\text{nil } I$, is the maximum integer k such that we can find elements $r_1, \dots, r_k \in I$ with $r_1 \cdots r_k \neq 0$.*

Proposition 1.6. *Let $p : E \rightarrow B$ be a fibration and let $p^* : H^*(B) \rightarrow H^*(E)$ be the induced homomorphism on cohomology. Then $\text{secat}(p) > \text{nil ker } p^*$.*

Definition 1.30. *Let G be a topological group and X be a space, and assume we have some continuous G -action on X (i.e. $(g, x) \mapsto g \cdot x$ is continuous). Then X is a G -space.*

Definition 1.31. *For $x \in X$ a G -space, the isotropy group or stabilizer group of x is*

$$G_x := \{g \in G : gx = x\}.$$

Remark 1.8. G_x is closed for all $x \in X$.

Proof. Fix some $x \in X$ and consider a point $g \in \overline{G_x}$. Then there is a net $\{g_d\}_{d \in D} \subseteq G_x$ such that $g_d \rightarrow g$. Since each $g_d x = x$ by definition, by continuity we have that $g_d x \rightarrow gx = x$, so $g \in G_x$ and G_x is closed. $\square$

Definition 1.32. *Given a G -space X and $x \in X$, the orbit of x is*

$$Gx := \{gx : g \in G\}.$$

Remark 1.9. *The map $\phi : G/G_x \rightarrow Gx$ given by $\phi(gG_x) = gx$ is a homeomorphism.*

Proof. First, let $g, g' \in G$ such that $gG_x = g'G_x$; we wish to show that $gx = g'x$. Since $gG_x = g'G_x$, there exists some $h \in G_x$ such that $ge = g'h$. Then we have

$$gx = gex = g'hx = g'x.$$

So ϕ is well-defined.

To see that ϕ is continuous, consider the quotient map $q : G \rightarrow G/G_x$; we wish to show that $\phi \circ q : G \rightarrow Gx$ is continuous. Observe that $\phi(q(g)) = \phi(gG_x) = gx$, so it immediately follows that $\phi \circ q$ is continuous.

Lastly, to see that ϕ is an open map, consider some open set $UG_x \subseteq G/G_x$. Then $\phi[UG_x] = Ux$ which is clearly open.

Therefore we conclude that ϕ is a homeomorphism. $\square$

Definition 1.33. *For a G -space X , the orbit space is X/G .*

Proposition 1.7. *If G is compact and X is a Hausdorff G -space, then X/G is Hausdorff.*

Proof. ³ First consider the equivalence relation given on X where xRy if x and y lie in the same orbit. This equivalence relation is then given by the following set:

$$R := \{(x, gx) : x \in X, g \in G\} = \bigcup_{x \in X} \{x\} \times Gx \subseteq X \times X.$$

We wish to show that R is closed, so let $\{(x_a, g_a x_a)\}_{a \in A} \subseteq R$ be a convergent net with $(x_a, g_a x_a) \rightarrow (x, y) \in X \times X$. Since G is compact, the net $\{g_a\}_{a \in A}$ has a convergent subnet $\{g_b\}_{b \in B}$ with $g_b \rightarrow g \in G$. Then by continuity we have that the subnet $\{(x_b, g_b x_b)\}_{b \in B}$ converges to $(x, gx) \in R$ so $y = gx$. Thus R is closed.

Additionally, observe that $x \mapsto gx$ is a homeomorphism for any $g \in G$, so for any open $U \subseteq X$, $GU = \bigcup_{g \in G} gU$ is open as well. Then with the quotient map $q : X \rightarrow X/G$, $q^{-1}[GU] = GU$ since GU is a union of orbits, so $GU \in X/G$ is open.

Now let $Gx, Gy \in X/G$ with $Gx \neq Gy$, so clearly x and y do not lie in the same orbit and $(x, y) \notin R$. Because R is closed in $X \times X$, we can find open sets $U, V \subseteq X$ such that $(x, y) \in U \times V$ and $(U \times V) \cap R = \emptyset$. We immediately have that $GU \cap GV = \emptyset$ as well since otherwise x and y would be in the same orbit. Therefore we conclude that X/G is Hausdorff. $\square$

Definition 1.34. *Given two G -spaces X and Y , $f : X \rightarrow Y$ is a G -map if for all $g \in G$, $f(gx) = g \cdot f(x)$. We write $f : X \rightarrow_G Y$.*

Definition 1.35. *Given two G -spaces X and Y , $h : X \times [0, 1] \rightarrow Y$ is a G -homotopy if h is a homotopy and $h(-, t)$ is a G -map for all $t \in [0, 1]$. Equivalently, h is a G -map with G acting trivially on $[0, 1]$ and diagonally on $X \times [0, 1]$. We write $h : X \times [0, 1] \rightarrow_G Y$ or $h_t : X \rightarrow_G Y$.*

Definition 1.36. *Two G -maps $f, g : X \rightarrow_G Y$ are G -homotopic if there is a G -homotopy $h_t : X \rightarrow_G Y$ such that $h_0 = f$ and $h_1 = g$. We write $f \simeq_G g$.*

Definition 1.37. *Two G -spaces X and Y are G -homotopy equivalent if there are G -maps $f : X \rightarrow_G Y$ and $g : Y \rightarrow_G X$ such that $g \circ f \simeq_G \text{id}_X$ and $f \circ g \simeq_G \text{id}_Y$.*

Definition 1.38. *A set $U \subseteq X$ is invariant if $gU \subseteq U$ for all $g \in G$. Note that $U \subseteq GU$ always, so U is invariant if and only if $U = GU$.*

Definition 1.39. *A G -map $f : X \rightarrow Y$ is a fixed orbit map if $f[X]$ is contained in a single orbit in Y .*

Definition 1.40. *An invariant set $U \subseteq X$ is G -categorical if the inclusion $i : U \rightarrow X$ is G -homotopic to a fixed orbit map.*

Definition 1.41. *The equivariant category of a G -space X , denoted $\text{cat}_G(X)$, is the least integer k such that X can be covered by k G -categorical open sets.*

Definition 1.42. *A G -space X is G -contractible if $\text{cat}_G(X) = 1$.*

³Got proof idea from this conversation with Claude.

Proposition 1.8. *X is G -contractible if and only if X is G -homotopy equivalent to G .*

Proof. First assume that X is G -contractible, and let $h_t : X \rightarrow_G X$ be a corresponding G -homotopy witnessing this where $h_0 = \text{id}_X$ and h_1 is a fixed orbit map. Let $x_0 \in X$ be some representative of the orbit $h_1[X]$, i.e. $Gx_0 = h_1[X]$. Observe that Gx_0 is trivially homeomorphic to G via the map $gx_0 \mapsto g$, so we conclude that $X \simeq_G G$.

Conversely, assume that $X \simeq_G G$ via $f : X \rightarrow_G G$ and $g : G \rightarrow_G X$ with corresponding G -homotopy $h_t : X \rightarrow_G X$ where $h_0 = g \circ f$ and $h_1 = \text{id}_X$. Observe that g must be a fixed orbit map since $g(h \cdot e) = h \cdot g(e)$ so $g[G] = Gg(e)$. Then $g \circ f$ is trivially a fixed orbit map since $(g \circ f)[X] \subseteq g[G]$, so we conclude that X is G -contractible via h_t . $\square$

Corollary 1.5. *For any topological group G acting on itself in the usual way, we have that $\text{cat}_G(G) = 1$.*

Proof. Clearly $G \simeq_G G$, so by proposition 1.8 we are done. $\square$

Proposition 1.9. *For any G -space X , $\text{cat}_G(X) \geq \text{cat}(X/G)$.*

Proof. Take $\text{cat}_G(X)$ -many G -categorical open sets U_j that cover X . Since each U_j is invariant, $U_j = GU_j \subseteq X/G$ is open. Then $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow X$ is G -homotopic to a fixed orbit map, so immediately we have that $q \circ i_j : GU_j \hookrightarrow X/G$ is homotopic to a constant map and each GU_j is null homotopic with $X/G = \cup_j GU_j$. $\square$

Proposition 1.10. *If X is metrizable and acted freely upon by G , then $\text{cat}_G(X) = \text{cat}(X/G)$.*

Definition 1.43. *The equivariant sectional category of a G -map $p : E \rightarrow_G B$, denoted $\text{secat}_G(p)$, is the least integer k such that B can be covered by k invariant open sets U_j that each admit a local G -homotopy section, i.e. there exists $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ such that $p \circ s \simeq_G i_j$ where $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$ is the inclusion.*

Proposition 1.11. *If $p : E \rightarrow_G B$ is a G -fibration, then $\text{secat}_G(p) \leq k$ if and only if B can be covered by k invariant open sets that each admit a local G -section.*

Proof. This follows by an argument analogous to remark 1.6. $\square$

Definition 1.44. *Given a G -space X and a closed subgroup $H \subseteq G$, the H -fixed point set of X is*

$$X^H := \{x \in X : \forall h \in H, hx = x\} = \{x \in X : Hx = \{x\}\}.$$

Definition 1.45. *A G -space X is G -connected if X^H is path-connected for every closed subgroup $H \subseteq G$.*

Proposition 1.12. *Let $p : E \rightarrow B$ be a G -map where B is G -connected and $E^G \neq \emptyset$. Then $\text{secat}_G(p) \leq \text{cat}_G(B)$.*

Proposition 1.13. *For a G -map $p : E \rightarrow_G B$, if $p[E^H] = B^H$ for all closed subgroups $H \subseteq G$, then $\text{secat}_G(p) \leq \text{cat}_G(B)$.*

Proposition 1.14. *If E is G -contractible then for any G -map $p : E \rightarrow_G B$ we have $\text{cat}_G(B) \leq \text{secat}_G(p)$.*

Proof. Since E is G -contractible, we have that $\text{id}_E \simeq_G c$ where $c : E \rightarrow_G E$ is a fixed orbit map. Now take $\text{secat}_G(p)$ -many invariant open sets $U_j \subseteq B$ such that $B = \cup_j U_j$ with maps $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ such that $s_j \simeq_G i_j$ where $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$ is the inclusion. Then we have

$$i_j \simeq_G p \circ s_j = p \circ \text{id}_E \circ s_j \simeq_G p \circ c \circ s_j$$

in which the latter map is a fixed orbit map since c is a fixed orbit map. Hence we conclude $\text{cat}_G(B) \leq \text{secat}_G(p)$. For clarity, this is represented in the following commutative diagram:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} E & \xrightarrow{\text{id}_E} & E \\ s_j \uparrow & \searrow c & \downarrow p \\ U_j & \xrightarrow{i_j} & B \end{array}$$

□

Corollary 1.6. *Let $p : E \rightarrow_G B$ be a G -map and let E be a G -contractible space such that one of the following holds:*

1. B is G -connected and $E^G \neq \emptyset$
2. $p[E^H] = B^H$ for all closed subgroups $H \subseteq G$.

Then $\text{secat}_G(p) = \text{cat}_G(p)$.

Proof. This immediately follows from propositions 1.12, 1.13, and 1.14. □

1.3 Background from [DLS24]

Definition 1.46. A map $f : X \rightarrow Y$ is (G) -invariant if for all $x \in X$ and for all $g \in G$, $f(g \cdot v) = f(v)$.

Definition 1.47. For a space X and group G , we denote X as a G -space with G acting trivially by X_{triv} .

Definition 1.48. We denote the category of topological spaces as **Top** and the category of G -spaces for fixed group G as G -**Top**.

Remark 1.10. A map $f : X \rightarrow Y$ is invariant if and only if it is a G -map when G acts trivially on Y , i.e. $f : X \rightarrow_G Y_{triv}$.

Remark 1.11. An invariant map $f : X \rightarrow Y$ induces a map $\hat{f} : X/G \rightarrow Y$ via $\hat{f}(Gv) = f(v)$. Conversely, a map $\hat{f} : X/G \rightarrow Y$ induces an invariant map $f : X \rightarrow Y$ via $f(v) = \hat{f}(Gv)$. This gives an isomorphism $\mathbf{Top}(X/G, Y) \cong G\text{-}\mathbf{Top}(X, Y_{triv})$.

Furthermore, let $L : G\text{-}\mathbf{Top} \rightarrow \mathbf{Top}$ and $R : \mathbf{Top} \rightarrow G\text{-}\mathbf{Top}$ be the functors defined as follows:

- $LX = X/G$, $L(f : X \rightarrow_G Y) = (Gx \mapsto G(f(x)))$
- $RY = Y_{triv}$, $R(f : Y \rightarrow X) = (y \mapsto f(y))$.

Then the previous isomorphism actually means that L is a left adjoint of R .

Definition 1.49. Given a G -space X , an orbit canonicalization is an invariant map $f : X \rightarrow X$ such that $f(x) \in Gx$ for all $x \in X$.

Remark 1.12. An orbit canonicalization $f : X \rightarrow X$ must have a unique fixed point in each orbit $Gx \in X/G$.

Proof. Remark 1.11 gives us an embedding $X/G \hookrightarrow X$, and we conclude by instead considering this embedding as a map $X \rightarrow X$. $\square$

Proposition 1.15. Every orbit canonicalization $f : X \rightarrow X$ corresponds uniquely to a continuous section $s : X/G \rightarrow X$.

Proof. First, let $f : X \rightarrow X$ be an orbit canonicalization. As per remark 1.11, f induces $\hat{f} : X/G \rightarrow X$ via $\hat{f}(Gx) = f(x)$ with $\hat{f} \circ q = f$. Since f is invariant, we have that $q(\hat{f}(Gx)) = q(f(x)) = G(f(x)) = Gx$ and so $\hat{f}$ is a section of q .

Conversely, let $s : X/G \rightarrow X$ be some section of q such that $s(Gx) \in Gx$ always. Then we can define a map $f : X \rightarrow X$ via $f = s \circ q$ and observe that $f(x) = s(q(x)) = s(Gx)$. Since s is a section of q , we have that $q(s(Gx)) = Gx$, meaning that $f(x) = s(Gx) \in q^{-1}[Gx] = Gx$. Therefore f is an orbit canonicalization.

Lastly, to see the uniqueness, observe that the process in the converse step applied to $\hat{f}$ yields f , so the map $f \mapsto \hat{f}$ is a bijection. $\square$

Corollary 1.7. An orbit canonicalization $f : X \rightarrow X$ exists if and only if there is a continuous section $s : X/G \rightarrow X$.

Proof. This is just a restatement of proposition 1.15. $\square$

Chapter 2

New Work

2.1 Sectional Category and Canonicalization

Proposition 2.1. *If there exists an orbit canonicalization $f : X \rightarrow X$, then $\text{secat}(q) = 1$ where $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ is the quotient map.*

Proof. By proposition 1.15 we know that f induces a section $\hat{f} : X/G \rightarrow X$ of q , so we conclude that $\text{secat}(q) = 1$. $\square$

Corollary 2.1. *If $\text{secat}(q) > 1$, there is no orbit canonicalization $f : X \rightarrow X$.*

With this in mind, we now wish to study the sectional category of the quotient map $q : X \rightarrow X/G$.

Definition 2.1. *For spaces E and B , a map $p : E \rightarrow B$ has the homotopy lifting property up to homotopy (HLPH) for a space X if for every homotopy $h_t : X \rightarrow B$ and every homotopy lift $\tilde{h}_0 : X \rightarrow E$ of h_0 ($h_0 \simeq p \circ \tilde{h}_0$), there exists a homotopy $\tilde{h}_t : X \rightarrow E$ that lifts h_t up to homotopy ($h_t \simeq p \circ \tilde{h}_t$).*

Proposition 2.2. *For any spaces E and B and a surjective map $p : E \rightarrow B$, $\text{secat}(p) \leq \text{cat}(B)$ as in definitions 1.11 and 1.13.*

Proof. Take $\text{cat}(B)$ -many open sets U_j such that $B = \cup_j U_j$ and each inclusion $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$ is homotopic to a constant map $c_j : U_j \rightarrow B$. $\square$

Definition 2.2. *For spaces E and B , a map $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a fibration up to homotopy if p satisfies the HLPH for all topological spaces.*

Remark 2.1. *Clearly HLP implies HLPH and any fibration is a fibration up to homotopy.*

Lemma 2.1. *Let X be a G -space and let $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ be the quotient map. Then if $U \subseteq X$ is G -categorical, the set $q[U] \subseteq X/G$ is contractible.*

Proof. First, let $U \subseteq X$ be G -categorical, i.e. the inclusion $i : U \hookrightarrow X$ is G -homotopic to a fixed orbit map $c : U \rightarrow X$. This clearly induces a homotopy from the inclusion $q \circ i : q[U] \hookrightarrow X/G$ to $q \circ c : q[U] \rightarrow X/G$, and since c is a fixed orbit map $q \circ c$ must be a constant map. Thus $q[U]$ is contractible. $\square$

Lemma 2.2. *Let X be a G space such that the quotient map $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ is a fibration. Then if $U \subseteq X/G$ is open and contractible, the set $q^{-1}[U] \subseteq X$ is G -categorical.*

Proof. Let $h_t : U \rightarrow X/G$ be a homotopy witnessing that U is contractible, with h_0 being the inclusion $i : U \hookrightarrow X/G$ and h_1 being a constant map $c : U \rightarrow X/G$. Set $V = q^{-1}[U]$, noting that V is open and invariant, and let $\tilde{h}_0 : V \rightarrow X$ be the inclusion $\tilde{i} : V \hookrightarrow X$. Then clearly $q \circ \tilde{h}_0 = i$, so by the homotopy lifting property we have a homotopy $\tilde{h}_t : V \rightarrow X$ such that $q \circ \tilde{h}_t = h_t$. Specifically this means $q \circ \tilde{h}_1 = c$, i.e. $\tilde{h}_1 : V \rightarrow X$ is a fixed orbit map, so we conclude that V is G -categorical. $\square$

Proposition 2.3. *If X is a G -space such that the quotient map $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ is a fibration up to homotopy, then $\text{secat}(q) \leq \text{cat}_G(X)$.*

Proof. Take $\text{cat}_G(X)$ -many G -categorical sets $U_j \subseteq X$ such that $X = \cup_j U_j$. Define $V_j = q[U_j]$, and note that by lemma 2.1 each V_j is contractible. Fix some j and let $h_t : V_j \rightarrow X/G$ be a homotopy witnessing the contractibility of V_j , with h_0 being a constant map $c_j : V_j \rightarrow X/G$ and h_1 being the inclusion $i_j : V_j \hookrightarrow X/G$. Then fix some $x_0 \in q^{-1}[c_j[V_j]]$ and define $\tilde{h}_0 : V_j \rightarrow X$ by $\tilde{h}_0 = c_{x_0}$. Clearly $q \circ \tilde{h}_0 = c_j$, so the HLPH gives us a homotopy $\tilde{h}_t : V_j \rightarrow X$ such that $q \circ \tilde{h}_t \simeq h_t$. In particular, this means $q \circ \tilde{h}_1 \simeq i_j$ so $\tilde{h}_1$ is a homotopy section of q . Repeating this for all j , we conclude that $\text{secat}(q) \leq \text{cat}_G(X)$. $\square$

Definition 2.3. *The contractible sectional category of a map $p : E \rightarrow B$, denoted by $\text{consecat}(p)$, is the least integer k such that B may be covered by k contractible open sets U_j that each admit a map $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ where $p \circ s_j$ is homotopic to the inclusion $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$.*

Remark 2.2. *Trivially, $\text{consecat}(p) \geq \text{secat}(p)$ for any map p .*

Proposition 2.4. *If X is a G -space such that the quotient map $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ is a fibration up to homotopy, then $\text{cat}_G(X) \leq \text{consecat}(q)$.*

Proof. Take $\text{consecat}(q)$ -many contractible open sets $U_j \subseteq X/G$ with $X/G = \cup_j U_j$ that each admit a homotopy section $s_j : U_j \rightarrow X$ of q . Define $V_j = q^{-1}[U_j]$, and note that by lemma 2.2 that each V_j is G -categorical. Clearly $X = \cup_j V_j$, so we conclude that $\text{cat}_G(X) \leq \text{consecat}(q)$. $\square$

Question 2.1. *The homotopy sections in the proof above are completely unused. Can something stronger be proven?*

Question 2.2. *When do we have $\text{consecat}(p) = \text{secat}(p)$? Or are there any other bounds we can put on $\text{secat}(p)$ via $\text{consecat}(p)$?*

Recall that when $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a fibration we have that definitions 1.11 and 1.27 coincide (i.e. homotopy sections induce sections), so we stand to learn a lot about orbit canonicalizations if we can discern when $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ is a fibration.

Theorem 2.1. *This is part of theorem 1.8 in [Rai06]. A fiber bundle $p : E \rightarrow B$ over paracompact space B is a fibration.*

2.2 Bounds for Strong and Weak Sectional Category

We first introduce some (slightly) new terminology.

Definition 2.4. *The weak sectional category of a map $p : E \rightarrow B$, denoted $\text{secat}(p)$, is the least integer k such that there k open sets U_j covering B that each admit a homotopy section $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ of p (i.e. $p \circ s_j \simeq i_j$ where $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$ is the inclusion).*

Definition 2.5. *The strong sectional category of a map $p : E \rightarrow B$, denoted $\text{secat}^{\text{str}}(p)$, is the least integer k such that there k open sets U_j covering B that each admit a section $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ of p (i.e. $p \circ s_j = i_j$ where $i_j : U_j \hookrightarrow B$ is the inclusion).*

Recall that by remark 1.6 $\text{secat}(p) = \text{secat}^{\text{str}}(p)$ when p is a fibration. In general, we have the following result:

Lemma 2.3. *For any map $p : E \rightarrow B$, $\text{secat}(p) \leq \text{secat}^{\text{str}}(p)$.*

Proof. Take $\text{secat}^{\text{str}}(p)$ -many open sets covering U_j with sections $s_j : U_j \rightarrow E$ of p i.e. $p \circ s_j = i_j$. It trivially follows that $p \circ s_j \simeq i_j$, so we are done. $\square$

Definition 2.6. (Definition 1.1 in [Coh26]) *Let E , B , and F be spaces, and let $p : E \rightarrow B$ be a map such that*

1. *p is surjective,*
2. *for all $b \in B$, $p^{-1}[\{b\}] \cong F$,*
3. *and for all $b \in B$, there is some open neighborhood $U_b \subseteq B$ of B and a homeomorphism $\Phi_b : p^{-1}[U_b] \rightarrow U_b \times F$ such that $p|_{p^{-1}[U_b]} = \pi_b \circ \Phi_b$ where $\pi_b : U_b \times F \rightarrow U_b$ is the projection.*

Then p is a fiber bundle with fiber F .

Lemma 2.4. (Corollary 2.7.14 in [Spa66]) *If B is paracompact, then any fiber bundle $p : E \rightarrow B$ is a fibration.*

Definition 2.7. (Definition 1.5 in [Coh26]) *A topological group G is a Lie group if G is a differentiable manifold such that products and inverses are differentiable maps.*

Definition 2.8. (Definition 1.6 in [Coh26]) *Let G be a topological group, let E and B be spaces, and let $p : E \rightarrow B$ be a fiber bundle with fiber G such that*

1. *E has a free left G -action where $p(e) = p(ge)$ for all $g \in G$, $e \in E$, i.e. the fibers of p are closed under the G -action,*
2. *for all $b \in B$, the induced G -action on $p^{-1}[\{b\}]$ is free and transitive,*
3. *and for every open set $U \subseteq B$, there exists a G -equivariant homeomorphism $\Psi_U : p^{-1}[U] \rightarrow G \times U$ where G acts on $G \times U$ by multiplication on G .*

Then p is a principal G -bundle.

Definition 2.9. (Definition 1.7 in [Coh26]) A G -space X has slices if the quotient map $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ has local sections around every point in X/G .

Proposition 2.5. (Proposition 1.2 in [Coh26]) If X is a free G -space with slices, then the quotient map $q : X \rightarrow X/G$ is a principal G -bundle.

Theorem 2.2. (Theorem 1.3 in [Coh26]) Let M be a smooth manifold with a smooth, free G -action by a compact Lie group G . Then M has slices.

Corollary 2.2. Let M be a smooth manifold with a smooth, free G -action by a compact Lie group G . Then $q : M \rightarrow M/G$ is a principal G -bundle.

Proof. This follows directly from theorem 2.2 and proposition 2.5. $\square$

Theorem 2.3. Let M be a smooth manifold with a smooth, free G -action by a compact Lie group G such that M/G is paracompact. Then $q : M \rightarrow M/G$ is a fibration.

Proof. This follows directly from corollary 2.2 and lemma 2.4. $\square$

Theorem 2.4. Let G be a compact Lie group and let M be a smooth manifold with submanifold $N \subseteq M$ such that

1. G acts smoothly on M ,
2. N is G -invariant (hence $N/G \subseteq M/G$),
3. the induced G -action on N is free,
4. and N/G is paracompact.

Then letting $q : M \rightarrow M/G$ and $p = q|_N : N \rightarrow N/G$ be the respective quotient maps and letting $p^* : H^*(N/G) \rightarrow H^*(N)$ be the induced map on cohomology, we have the following chain of inequalities:

$$\text{nil ker}(p^*) < \text{secat}(p) = \text{secat}^{\text{str}}(p) \leq \text{secat}^{\text{str}}(q).$$

Proof. Since G is a compact Lie group acting freely on N and N/G is paracompact, by theorem 2.3 we know that p is a fibration. Then by proposition 1.6 we have that $\text{nil ker}(p^*) < \text{secat}(p)$; by remark 1.6 we have that $\text{secat}(p) = \text{secat}^{\text{str}}(p)$; and by lemma 1.2 we have that $\text{secat}^{\text{str}}(p) \leq \text{secat}^{\text{str}}(q)$. $\square$

Theorem 2.4 gives a concrete method to find a lower bound for strong sectional category even for quotient maps that fail to be fibrations by considering appropriate submanifolds of a given space. This is particularly useful in the problem of orbit canonicalization, since orbit canonicalizations are directly related to the strong sectional category of the quotient map.

2.3 Canonicalizing $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$

Definition 2.10. The orthogonal group of degree n is the set

$$O(n) := \{Q \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n} : QQ^T = I\}.$$

Definition 2.11. The special orthogonal group of degree n is the set

$$SO(n) := \{Q \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n} : \det(Q) = 1\}.$$

Remark 2.3. Observe that $SO(n) \subseteq O(n)$.

Definition 2.12. The set of positive semi-definite matrices of degree n is

$$\mathbb{S}_+^n := \{A \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n} : A = A^T, \forall x \in \mathbb{R}^n, x^T A x \geq 0\}.$$

Definition 2.13. The set of positive semi-definite matrices of degree n with at most rank d is

$$\mathbb{S}_{\leq d}^n := \{A \in \mathbb{S}_+^n : \text{rank}(A) \leq d\}.$$

Remark 2.4. $\mathbb{S}_{\leq d}^n = \mathbb{S}_{\leq n}^n$ for any $d \geq n$.

Proposition 2.6. $A \in \mathbb{S}_+^n$ if and only if there is some matrix $B \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$ such that $A = B^T B$ [Wik26a].

Corollary 2.3. $\mathbb{S}_+^n = \mathbb{S}_{\leq n}^n$.

Definition 2.14. The set of positive semi-definite matrices of degree n with rank d is

$$\mathbb{S}_d^n := \{A \in \mathbb{S}_+^n : \text{rank}(A) = d\}.$$

Proposition 2.7. $A \in \mathbb{S}_d^n$ if and only if there is some matrix $B \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$ such that $A = B^T B$ with $\text{rank}(B) = d$. [Wik26a].

Lemma 2.5. With $O(d)$ acting on $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$ via matrix multiplication on the left, $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}/O(d)$ is homeomorphic to the space $S := \{A^T A : A \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}\}$.

Proof. To begin, consider the map $\phi : \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$ given by $\phi(A) = A^T A$. Now let $A, B \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$ such that $[A] = [B] \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}/O(d)$, i.e. there exists $Q \in O(d)$ such that $A = QB$. This means that $A^T A = (QB)^T QB = B^T Q^T QB = B^T B$, so ϕ induces a map $\hat{\phi} : \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}/O(d) \rightarrow S$ via $\hat{\phi}([A]) = A^T A$. Note that $\hat{\phi}$ is bijective by construction, with inverse $\hat{\phi}^{-1} : S \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}/O(d)$ given by $\hat{\phi}^{-1}(A^T A) = [A]$. Both of these maps are continuous, so we are done. $\square$

Corollary 2.4. $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}/O(d) \cong \mathbb{S}_{\leq d}^n$.

Proof. This follows directly from proposition 2.7 and lemma 2.5. $\square$

With corollary 2.4 in hand, we have that any invariant map $f : \mathbb{R}^{d \times n} \rightarrow Y$ factors through $\mathbb{S}_d^n$ and so it suffices to reduce to consider maps from $\mathbb{S}_d^n$ to Y .

Definition 2.15. Given a group G and a G -set X , the free locus of X is

$$X_{\text{free}} := \{x \in X : \forall g \in G \setminus \{e\}, gx \neq x\} = \{x \in X : G_x = \{e\}\}$$

Lemma 2.6. With $O(d)$ acting on $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$ via matrix multiplication, $\mathbb{R}_{\text{free}}^{d \times n} = \mathbb{R}_*^{d \times n}$.

Proof. First, let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$ such that $\text{rank}(A) = k < d$. Then there are some orthonormal bases $\{e_1, \dots, e_k\}$ of $\text{col}(A)$ and $\{e_{k+1}, \dots, e_d\}$ of $\text{null}(A)$. Let $B = [e_1 \cdots e_d]^T \in O(d)$ be the change of basis matrix from the standard basis for $\mathbb{R}^d$ to $\{e_1, \dots, e_d\}$. Then A can be written in the basis $\{e_1, \dots, e_d\}$ as a matrix

$$\widehat{A} = BA = \begin{bmatrix} \widehat{a}_{1,1} & \cdots & \widehat{a}_{n,1} \\ \vdots & & \vdots \\ \widehat{a}_{k,1} & \cdots & \widehat{a}_{n,k} \\ 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ \vdots & & \vdots \\ 0 & \cdots & 0 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Now define the matrix $R \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ by $R_{i,i} = 1$ if $i \leq k$, $R_{i,i} = -1$ if $i > k$, and $R_{i,j} = 0$ if $i \neq j$ (R simply flips the sign of the last $d - k$ coordinates) and observe that clearly $R \in O(d)$. Define $Q = B^T R B$, and then $Q \in O(d)$ since

$$Q^T Q = (B^T R B)^T B^T R B = B^T R^T B B^T R B = I.$$

By construction we have that $R\widehat{A} = \widehat{A}$, so it follows that $QA = A$. However, without loss of generality $Q \neq I$, so we have that $A \notin \mathbb{R}_{\text{free}}^{d \times n}$.

Conversely, let $A \in \mathbb{R}_*^{d \times n}$ and let $Q \in O(d)$ such that $QA = A$. Since $\text{col}(A) = \mathbb{R}^d$, this means that Q fixes all of $\mathbb{R}^d$ and hence $Q = I$. Therefore $A \in \mathbb{R}_{\text{free}}^{d \times n}$. $\square$

Corollary 2.5. $O(d)$ does not act freely on any subset of $\mathbb{R}^{d \times n}$ if $n < d$.

Corollary 2.6. $\mathbb{R}_*^{d \times n} / O(d) \cong \mathbb{S}_d^n$.

Proof. This follows from proposition 2.7, lemma 2.5, and lemma 2.6. $\square$

Definition 2.16. (From [BZA24]) The Stiefel manifold $V_k(n)$ is the set of orthonormal basis matrices for k -dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^n$, which can be represented via

$$V_k(n) := \{U \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times k} : U^T U = I \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times k}\}$$

Definition 2.17. (From [BZA24]) The Grassmann manifold $G_k(n)$ is the set of all k -dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^n$. This can be represented with the set of all rank k orthogonal projection matrices via

$$G_k(n) := \{P \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n} : P^T = P, P^2 = P, \text{rank}(P) = k\}.$$

Remark 2.5. The Grassmann manifold $G_k(n)$ can also be realized as a quotient of the Stiefel manifold $V_k(n)$ by relating matrices that are basis for the same subspace, i.e. those that differ by an orthogonal transformation. This is captured by the action of $O(k)$ on $S_k(n)$ by right multiplication, hence $G_k(n) \cong V_k(n) / O(k)$.

Both of these manifolds are compact, and have corresponding non-compact variants:

Definition 2.18. *The non-compact Stiefel manifold $V'_k(n)$ is the set of basis matrices for k -dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^n$, which can be represented via*

$$V_k(n) := \{U \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times k} : \text{rank}(U) = k\}$$

Definition 2.19. *The non-compact Grassmann manifold $G'_k(n)$ is $V'_k(n)/O(k)$ where $O(k)$ acts on $V'_k(n)$ on the right via matrix multiplication.*

Remark 2.6. *There is a one-to-one correspondence between $\mathbb{R}_*^{d \times n}$ and $V_d(n)$ via $A \mapsto A^T$.*

Bibliography

- [BZA24] Thomas Bendokat, Ralf Zimmermann, and P.-A. Absil. “A Grassmann manifold handbook: basic geometry and computational aspects”. In: *Advances in Computational Mathematics* 50.1 (Jan. 2024). ISSN: 1572-9044. DOI: 10.1007/s10444-023-10090-8. URL: <http://dx.doi.org/10.1007/s10444-023-10090-8>.
- [CG13] Hellen Colman and Mark Grant. “Equivariant topological complexity”. In: *Algebraic & Geometric Topology* 12.4 (2013), pp. 2299–2316.
- [Coh26] Ralph Cohen. *The Topology of Fiber Bundles (Lecture Notes)*. [Online; accessed 22-May-2026]. 2026. URL: <https://math.stanford.edu/~ralph/fiber.pdf>.
- [DLS24] Nadav Dym, Hannah Lawrence, and Jonathan W. Siegel. *Equivariant Frames and the Impossibility of Continuous Canonicalization*. 2024. arXiv: 2402.16077 [cs.LG]. URL: <https://arxiv.org/abs/2402.16077>.
- [Far06] Michael Farber. “Topology of robot motion planning”. In: *Morse theoretic methods in nonlinear analysis and in symplectic topology*. Springer, 2006, pp. 185–230.
- [Rai06] Armin Rainer. *Orbit projections as fibrations*. 2006. arXiv: math/0610513 [math.DG]. URL: <https://arxiv.org/abs/math/0610513>.
- [Spa66] Edwin H. Spanier. *Algebraic Topology*. New York, NY: Springer, 1966. ISBN: 978-1-4684-9322-1. DOI: 10.1007/978-1-4684-9322-1. URL: <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-4684-9322-1>.
- [Wik26a] Wikipedia contributors. *Definite matrix* — *Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia*. [Online; accessed 19-May-2026]. 2026. URL: https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Definite_matrix&oldid=1354984805.
- [Wik26b] Wikipedia contributors. *Fibration* — *Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia*. [Online; accessed 19-May-2026]. 2026. URL: <https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Fibration&oldid=1333694611>.
- [Wik26c] Wikipedia contributors. *Lebesgue covering dimension* — *Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia*. [Online; accessed 14-May-2026]. 2026. URL: https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Lebesgue_covering_dimension&oldid=1353669095.